

Lesson 6: Turn Projects Into Proof

What You're Doing Today

You already have a portfolio skeleton, a bio, one case study, and a brand kit. Today you write two more case studies — bringing you to the 2–3 required — and you decide, using a scoring system instead of a gut feeling, exactly which projects make the final cut.

Why This Matters

Right now you probably have a list of things you've built. A list of things you've built is not a portfolio. The difference between "a thing I made" and "proof" is what you say about it. Anyone can list "Built a website." That sentence proves nothing — not that you can code, not that you solved a real problem, not that you finished what you started. A reviewer (a mentor, a college, an employer, a client) reading your portfolio is asking one question underneath everything else: *can I trust that this person can actually do the thing?* Vague claims don't answer that. Specific, honest, skill-revealing case studies do.

What Makes a Project "Proof" — Three Tests

1. **Specificity.** Name the actual tool, the actual constraint, the actual number. "I built a weather app" is a thing you made. "I built a weather app that pulls live data from a public API and caches results so it still works offline" is proof — it names a real technical decision.
2. **Honesty.** Never claim more than what happened. If you worked on a team, say your specific part. If it's not deployed, don't say it's "in production." If a tutorial got you 80% of the way there, say what the remaining 20% was — that's often the most impressive part.
3. **Demonstrated skill.** Every strong case study makes an invisible decision visible. Not just what you built, but why you built it that way, or how you got unstuck when it broke.

Worked Example: Weak Case Study → Strong Rewrite

Weak version (a fictional student, "Sam"):

Project: School Website **What I did:** Made a website for my school's robotics club using HTML and CSS. It has information about the club and looks nice. I learned a lot about web design and it was a fun project.

Notice: no specific problem, no specific tool decisions, no specific outcome, no specific skill named. This could describe almost any student's first website.

Strong rewrite of the same real project:

Project Name: Robotics Club Recruitment Site **Problem/Goal:** Our robotics club had no way to show new students what we do before they showed up to a meeting — sign-ups were low. I needed a site that explained the club fast and made joining easy. **Tools Used:** HTML, CSS, GitHub Pages for free hosting. **My Approach:** I interviewed three club officers to find out what questions new members actually ask, then built the site around those questions instead of a generic "About Us" page. I used CSS Grid to make the meeting schedule readable on phones, since most students said they'd check it on their phone between classes. **Result:** The site went live two weeks before recruitment season. Club sign-ups that mentioned "saw it on the website" went from effectively zero the year before to 9 new members. **What I Learned:** That good design starts with asking real users what they need, not guessing. Also learned to debug a layout that broke only on mobile Safari — turned out to be a flexbox default I didn't know about.

Same project. The difference is entirely in what's said about it: a real problem, a real decision (interviewing officers, choosing CSS Grid for a reason), an honest and specific result, and a specific thing learned.

Step-by-Step Activity

Step 1 — List every candidate project. Write down everything you've built: Lumexa class projects, personal projects, school assignments, group projects. Don't filter yet.

Step 2 — Score them on the Worksheet. For each project, rate Complexity (1–5), Completeness (1–5), and write one sentence for "what it proves." Be honest — an unfinished ambitious idea is not the same as a finished simple one.

Step 3 — Choose your 2–3 strongest. You already have one case study from Lesson 4. Pick your next 2 highest-scoring, most provable projects — not your 2 most complicated ones if they're incomplete, and not your 2 easiest ones if they prove nothing.

Step 4 — Write two new case studies. Use the same template from Lesson 4: Project Name, Problem/Goal, Tools Used, My Approach, Result, What I Learned. Apply all three proof tests as you write.

Step 5 — Cross-check with your brand kit. Pull up your Lesson 5 brand kit. Does the tone/voice of these new case studies match your Lesson 4 one and your bio? Same level of formality? Same style of sentence? A portfolio where every page sounds like a different person is confusing — fix any mismatches now.

Key Terms

- **Case study:** A structured, specific write-up of one project — problem, approach, result, lesson learned.
- **Proof:** Evidence that lets someone else verify a skill or outcome, as opposed to a claim they have to take on faith.

- **Complexity:** How many real technical decisions a project required.
- **Completeness:** Whether a project actually works end-to-end and can be shown, not just described.
- **Brand consistency:** Using the same tone, vocabulary, and style across every piece of your portfolio so it reads as one person, not several drafts.

Knowledge Checks

1. What are the three tests a project must pass to count as "proof"?
2. Why might a simple, fully finished project beat a complex, half-finished one on a portfolio?
3. Give one example of a vague sentence and rewrite it to be specific.
4. Why is honesty about your exact role on a group project more persuasive than exaggerating it?
5. What should you check your new case studies against, from Lesson 5, before finalizing them?

Reflection Prompts

1. Which of your projects did you almost include out of habit, but the rubric convinced you to leave out — and why?
2. What's one specific technical decision you made on a project that you'd never thought to mention before today?
3. How did writing an honest "What I Learned" section change how you think about a project that didn't go perfectly?

Submission Instructions

Submit, in your course folder: 1. Your completed Project Selection & Proof Rubric (scoring table for at least 4 candidate projects, with your final include/exclude decision marked). 2. Two new project case studies (Google Doc or plain text), using the six-part template. 3. A one-sentence note confirming you checked your new case studies against your Lesson 5 brand kit for tone consistency.